

Final Judgment

doc-final-judgment

Eschatology · Judgment · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants not in scope

Statement under examination

Christ will judge all people at his return: believers to eternal life, unbelievers to eternal punishment.

In plain language

The Greek behind these passages lines up tightly. Three related judgment words carry the weight: the verb 'to judge' (krino, 115 occurrences), the noun 'judgment' (krisis, 48), and a related noun for 'sentence' (krima, 27). Acts 17:31 says God will judge ('to judge,' krinein) the whole inhabited world in righteousness through a man he appointed and certified by raising him from the dead. Hebrews 9:27 sets a plain sequence for human beings: once to die, and after that 'judgment' (krisis). Revelation 20:12 and 13 use the same verb in the aorist passive (a completed past action in passive voice), 'they were judged' (ekrithesan), the dead were judged, and twice adds the standard, according to their works ('according to the works,' kata ta erga). So the texts agree on who judges, that it reaches everyone, and that deeds are the measure. The Old Testament supplies the same pattern with the Hebrew verb 'to judge' (shafat) and the noun 'judgment' (mishpat); Ecclesiastes 12:14 says God brings every work into judgment, and Daniel 7:10 places the court and the opened books before the Ancient of Days. The two outcomes are also explicit and balanced. Matthew 25:46 ends the throne scene with a single sentence holding two destinations side by side: these go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life. One and the same adjective, 'eternal' (aionios), modifies both punishment and life, so whatever lasting force it gives the reward it gives the penalty. Romans 2:6 to 9 repeats the shape: God renders to each according to his works, eternal life for the patient in good, but wrath and distress for the self-seeking, and verse 11 caps it with no partiality. 2 Corinthians 5:10 names the seat itself, the 'judgment seat' (bema) of Christ, before which all of us must appear so that each may receive according to what he has done, whether good or bad. Two places of real lexical underdetermination (where the words alone do not settle the question) are worth naming, because they explain divergence among careful readers. First, the word 'punishment' (kolasis) appears only twice in the New Testament (Matthew 25:46 and 1 John 4:18), so its sense cannot be triangulated from canonical use alone, which is the seam where a softer corrective reading tries to enter; the parallel grammar of Matthew 25:46 holds the two outcomes together. Second, Paul uses 'judgment seat' (bema) of Christ in 2 Corinthians 5:10 and Romans 14:10, while Revelation 20 uses 'throne' (thronos) for the judgment of the dead, and the vocabulary does not by itself decide whether these describe one event from two angles or two distinct events. The agent, the scope, and the two outcomes are lexically secure; the timing and event-count are where the words leave room.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1780	דִּין	din	judgment	
H4941	מִשְׁפָּט	mishpat	justice	
H6663	צַדִּיק	tsadaq	to justify	

H8199	שָׁפַט	shafat	to judge	184
G0166	αἰώνιος	aionios	eternal	69
G0444	ἄνθρωποις	anthrōpos	a human	
G0968	βῆμα	bema	judgement seat	12
G0975	βιβλίον	biblion	scroll	35
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	
G1538	ἐκαστος	hekastos	each	82
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	176
G2222	ζωή	zoe	life	136
G2596	κατά	kata	according to	477
G2851	κόλασις	kolasis	punishment	2
G2917	κρίμα	krima	judgment	27
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	115
G2920	κρίσις	krisis	judgment	48
G3498	νεκρός	nekros	dead	132
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,263
G4442	πῦρ	pyr	fire	72

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The judgment word-group, the verb 'to judge' (krino, G2919, 115 New Testament occurrences), the noun 'judgment' (krisis, G2920, 48 occurrences), and the related noun 'sentence or verdict' (krima, G2917, 27 occurrences), recurs across the Gospels, Acts, the letters, and apocalyptic (visionary end-time) writing. Acts 17:31 sets a fixed day on which God 'is about to judge' (mellei krinein) the inhabited world by an appointed man whom God raised. Hebrews 9:27 makes 'to die' (apothanein) 'once' (hapax, a word here meaning 'one time only') then 'judgment' (krisis) the human sequence. Revelation 20:12-13 reads 'they were judged' (ekrithesan, the aorist passive, a completed past action in passive voice) twice with 'according to the works' (kata ta erga) as the standard. Two outcomes are lexically explicit and grammatically symmetrical: Matthew 25:46 attaches one adjective 'eternal' (aionios, G0166) to both 'punishment' (kolasin, G2851) and 'life' (zoen, G2222) in a single sentence, and Romans 2:7-9 pairs 'eternal life' (zoen aionion) with 'wrath and fury' (orge kai thymos). Universality is carried by 'all' (pantas) in 2 Corinthians 5:10, 'all the nations' (panta ta ethne) in Matthew 25:32, 'to human beings' (tois anthropois) in Hebrews 9:27, and the Old Testament pattern of the Hebrew verb 'to judge' (shafat, H8199, 184 occurrences) judging all the earth. The verdict holds; the anchor lemmas (dictionary forms) span both testaments.

Scripture

Matt.25.46 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0166 αἰώνιον, G2222 ζῶην, G2851 κόλασιν

Force. The verse closes the throne scene with two destinations in strict grammatical balance: 'and these will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life' (kai apeleusontai houtoi eis kolasin aionion, hoi de dikaioi eis zoen aionion). The same adjective 'eternal' (aionios, G0166) modifies both 'punishment' (kolasin, G2851) and 'life' (zoen, G2222). A canon-wide query shows 'eternal' (aionios) pairs with 'life' (zoe) in more than thirty verses and pairs with 'fire' (pyr) in three places (Matthew 18:8, Matthew 25:41, Jude 7), but pairs with 'punishment' (kolasis) only here. The contrast is binary, the righteous ('the righteous ones,' dikaioi) against the cursed of the preceding verses, with no third outcome named.

Rev.20.12 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2919 ἐκρίθησαν, G2041 ἔργα, G0975 βιβλία

Force. The dead, great and small, stand before the throne and 'books' (biblia) were opened, and 'the dead were judged from the things written in the books according to their works' (ekrithesan hoi nekroi ek ton gegrammenon en tois bibliois kata ta erga auton). The aorist passive 'they were judged' (ekrithesan, the aorist passive, a completed past action in passive voice, from the verb 'to judge,' krino G2919) names a completed judgment act, and 'according to the works' (kata ta erga) fixes the standard as deeds. Verse 15 then assigns those not found written in the book of life to the lake of fire, the lexical pairing of records with outcome. The same root recurs in Revelation 20:13 ('they were judged,' ekrithesan), tying the throne sequence into a single judgment cluster.

Acts.17.31 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2919 κρίνειν, G3956 πᾶσιν, G3498 νεκρῶν

Force. God set a 'day' (hemera) in which he is about 'to judge' (mellei krinein, from the verb 'to judge,' G2919) the 'inhabited world' (oikoumene) in righteousness by a man whom he 'appointed' (horisen), having given assurance 'to all' (pasin) by raising him 'from the dead' (ek nekron). The judging agent is a designated man tied to resurrection, the scope is the inhabited world, and the standard is 'righteousness' (dikaiosyne). This supplies the agency and universality of the proposition. The grammar holds the appointed day and the appointed man together in a single divine act.

Heb.9.27 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2920 κρίσις, G0444 ἄνθρωποις

Force. 'Inasmuch as it is appointed for human beings once to die, and after this judgment' (kath hoson apokeitai tois anthropois hapax apothanein, meta de touto krisis). The clause sets a fixed sequence for human beings ('to human beings,' tois anthropois, dative of reference, a noun in the 'with respect to' grammatical form): once to die, and after this 'judgment' (krisis, G2920). The single death is matched by a single subsequent judgment, with no qualifier limiting it to one class of person. The adverb 'once' (hapax, a word here meaning 'one time only') is paralleled in v.28 with Christ offered 'once' (hapax), so the literary frame locks one death and one judgment to one offering.

2Cor.5.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0968 βήματος, G3956 πάντας, G1538 ἕκαστος

Force. 'For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, that each one may receive what is due for the things done through the body, whether good or bad' (tous gar pantas hemas dei phanerothenai emprosthen tou bematou tou Christou, hina komisetai hekastos ta dia tou somatos pros ha epraxen, eite agathon eite phaulon). The 'judgment seat' (bema, G0968, 12 New Testament occurrences mostly in Acts judicial scenes plus Romans 14:10) is explicitly 'of Christ' (tou Christou), the subjects are 'all of us' (tous pantas), and recompense is per individual ('each one,' hekastos) according to deeds done, sorted 'good' (agathon) against 'worthless or bad' (phaulon). This grounds Christ as judge and the per-person, deed-indexed character of the assessment.

Rom.2.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1538 ἐκάστω, G2041 ἔργα, G2596 κατὰ

Force. 'Who will render to each one according to his works' (hos apodosei hekasto kata ta erga autou), then verses 7-9 unfold the two outcomes: to those persevering in good work, 'eternal life' (zoeon aionion); to the self-seeking who disobey the truth, 'wrath and fury, tribulation and distress' (orge kai thymos, thlipsis kai stenochoria). Verse 11 closes with 'for there is no partiality with God' (ou gar estin prosopolempsia para to theo), no partiality, and v.16 names the day God judges the secrets of men 'through Christ Jesus' (dia Christou Iesou). The lexical frame is render-to-each, two destinies, impartial standard, with Christ as the operative agent.

Eccl.12.14 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H4941 כּוֹל

Force. 'For God will bring every deed into judgment, with every secret thing' (ki et kol-maaseh ha-Elohim yavi ve-mishpat al kol-ne'lam). The verse closes Qoheleth (the Hebrew name for the book of Ecclesiastes) with God bringing every work into 'judgment' (mishpat, H4941), including every hidden thing. The scope marker 'every' (kol) twice and the parallel to 'work' (ergon) in Revelation 20:12 and 2 Corinthians 5:10 establishes the deed-indexed comprehensive judgment in the Old Testament terms the New Testament then carries forward.

Dan.7.10 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. H1780 דִּין

Force. 'The court sat in judgment, and the books were opened' (dina yetiv ve-sifrin petichu). A judgment 'court' (dina, the Aramaic word for court or judgment) was seated and 'books' (sifrin) were opened before the Ancient of Days. The pairing of throne, court, and opened books is the lexical template Revelation 20:11-12 reuses ('throne,' thronos; 'books were opened,' biblia eneothesan; 'they were judged,' ekritheisan), so the apocalyptic (visionary end-time) judgment scene is not a New Testament innovation but a canonical pattern.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rev.20.12	Dan.7.10	tsk	3
Rev.20.12	Eccl.12.14	openbible	2
Rom.2.11	Deut.10.17	tsk	1
Rom.2.9	Ezek.18.4	tsk	1
2Cor.5.10	Gen.18.25	tsk	2
2Cor.5.10	Rom.14.10	openbible	4
Heb.9.27	Gen.3.19	tsk	1
Matt.25.46	Dan.12.2	openbible	5
Acts.17.31	Ps.96.13	tsk	2

Complicating texts

Matt.25.46 · addressed

The noun 'punishment' (kolasis, G2851) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in this judgment sense (only 2 New Testament occurrences, here and 1 John 4:18 where it means the inward dread of an unloving heart), so its lexical range cannot be triangulated from canonical use alone. A reading that presses 'punishment' (kolasis) toward remedial correction rather than retributive punishment relies on extra-canonical Greek usage. The grammar inside the verse resists that move because 'eternal' (aionios, G0166) modifies 'punishment' (kolasin) and 'life' (zoe) identically in the same sentence, and a canon-wide query shows 'eternal' (aionios) habitually attaches to 'life' (zoe) (more than thirty pairings) as a positive durational term, so whatever durational weight the adjective gives to life it gives to the penalty. The symmetry is load-bearing.

2Cor.5.10 · addressed

The 'judgment seat' (bema, G0968) language differs from the great white throne language of Revelation 20:11-15. One reading takes the 'judgment seat' (bema) of 2 Corinthians 5:10 and Romans 14:10 as a believer-only assessment of works distinct from a separate general judgment of the dead; another reading takes the lexical material as one judgment described from different angles. The lexicon presents 'judgment seat' (bema) in Acts as a generic judicial dais and reserves 'throne' (thronos) for Revelation 20, but neither term lexically requires that the events be one or two. This is a sequencing question the vocabulary underdetermines, and the verdict on agent, scope, and two outcomes holds either way.

Acts.17.31 · addressed

The proposition says Christ judges at his return, but Acts 17:31 names a set 'day' (hemera) and an appointed man without explicitly fusing the judging day to the second-coming event ('parousia,' Christ's coming or arrival). The cited New Testament data establishes Christ as the appointed judge and a comprehensive judgment but does not by itself collapse every judgment text to one moment. This is noted in the stem audit; the core claim of agency, universality, and two outcomes is unaffected.

Concordance traversed

G2919, G2920, G2917, G0166, G2222, G2851, G4442, G2041, G0968, G3498, G0975, G1538, G3956, G2596, G1391, H8199, H6663

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The anchor verses sit outside the ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) published window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15). The SBLGNT apparatus marks minor sigla at Revelation 20:11 ('upon his face,' epi tou prosopou autou, ordering) and Matthew 25:31 (article variants, that is, presence or absence of the article 'the'), and TR (Textus Receptus) readings at Revelation 20:12 vary on the genitive (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form) of 'book' (biblos), but none of the recorded variant units touches the operative lexemes (the dictionary words at issue): 'to judge' (krino), 'judgment' (krisis), 'sentence' (krima), 'eternal' (aionios), 'punishment' (kolasis), 'work' (ergon), or 'judgment seat' (bema), nor the binary clause structure of Matthew 25:46. The verdict is variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. two-stage-judgment, single-general-judgment, annihilationism, universalism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

two-stage-judgment: compatible · A reading that distinguishes the 'judgment seat' (bema) of 2 Corinthians 5:10 and Romans 14:10 as a believer-specific assessment from the 'throne' (thronos) of Revelation 20:11-15 as the judgment of the dead takes the differing terminology ('judgment seat' bema vs 'throne' thronos) and differing subject markers ('all of us,' pantas hemas, in 2 Corinthians vs 'the dead ones,' hoi nekroi, in Revelation 20) as lexical signals of two events. The vocabulary permits this distinction but does not compel it.

single-general-judgment: compatible · A reading that takes Matthew 25:31-46, Revelation 20:11-15, 2 Corinthians 5:10, Acts 17:31, and Hebrews 9:27 as different descriptions of one event leans on the shared 'to judge' (krino)

word-group, the shared 'according to the works' (kata ta erga) standard, and the shared universal scope ('all,' pantes; 'all the nations,' panta ta ethne; 'to human beings,' tois anthropois). The vocabulary permits this fusion but does not compel it either, since 'judgment seat' (bema) and 'throne' (thronos) are not interchangeable in their other New Testament occurrences.

annihilationism: weakly-complicates · A reading that takes the second death and lake of fire as cessation of being rather than ongoing conscious penalty leans on 'destruction' (apoleia) and 'to die' (apothnesko) language. The parallel grammar of Matthew 25:46, where one 'eternal' (aionios) modifies both clauses, is the main lexical pressure against this reading: whatever durational sense 'eternal' (aionios) gives 'the righteous ones' (dikaioi) it gives 'the punishment' (kolasis).

universalism: complicates · A reading that takes 'punishment' (kolasis) as remedial correction culminating in restoration relies on the extra-canonical sense of 'punishment' (kolasis) as discipline. The canonical data (only 2 New Testament occurrences of 'punishment,' kolasis) cannot triangulate this sense, and the grammar of Matthew 25:46 attaches the same 'eternal' (aionios) to both clauses, which the universalist reading must then construe non-symmetrically.

Each text is read for its own grammar first, then the shared word-group ('to judge,' krino; 'judgment,' krisis; 'sentence,' krima; 'eternal,' aionios; 'according to the works,' kata ta erga) and the repeated two-destination structure are compared across the canon. Old Testament cross-references (Daniel 7:10 books opened, Genesis 18:25 the Judge of all the earth, Ecclesiastes 12:14 every work into judgment) show the pattern is not novel to the New Testament. The two competing event-structures (one judgment vs two judgments) are recorded symmetrically; the verdict on agent, scope, and outcome does not depend on resolving them.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Christ judges all people, assigning two outcomes, eternal life and eternal punishment, on a deed-indexed and impartial standard.

The stem phrase 'at his return' fuses the timing of judgment with the second advent (Christ's second coming). The lexical data names Christ or an appointed man as judge (Acts 17:31, 2 Corinthians 5:10, Romans 2:16), a comprehensive scope, and two outcomes, but the cited texts do not uniformly pin the judgment to a single return-event. Revelation 20 sits in a distinct narrative slot after the millennium (the thousand-year period) in the Apocalypse sequence, and 2 Corinthians 5:10 uses 'judgment seat' (bema) not 'throne' (thronos). The verdict was derived on the original stem; the temporal clause is flagged so the affirmation rests on agent, scope, and outcome rather than on a contested chronology. Audited anchors: 'to judge' (krino, G2919), 'judgment' (krisis, G2920), 'sentence' (krima, G2917), 'judgment seat' (bema, G0968), 'eternal' (aionios, G0166), 'punishment' (kolasis, G2851), and the Revelation 20 throne scene.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.20.12
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.25.46
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0166
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2920
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2919
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2851
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0968
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8199
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4941
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Cor.5.10
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.25.46

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rev.20.12
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Matt.25.46
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	Heb.9.27
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eccl.12.14

License audit

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Reason. One source is non-redistributable in bulk: MACULA-Greek under CC-BY-NC-4.0. It was used because the MACULA-Greek syntax layer carries the 'judgment seat' (bema) clause structure of 2 Corinthians 5:10 and the symmetric two-destination clause structure of Matthew 25:46, which is load-bearing for the verdict, so the aggregate is not safe to bulk-publish.

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